Educational Design Paper 1: Schooling as a Means of Community Engagement

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What should be the purpose of schooling? Who should it serve and what needs should it address? To answer these questions, we first need to examine the needs of our youth. Research on wellbeing suggests that few things impact happiness as much as an ability to contribute. One MIT Technology Report from 2005 says that "Nothing – not even divorce – makes people more unhappy than unemployment" (Surowiecki, 2005). While lost income surely contributes to this statistic, I believe the findings point to something deeper. People want to have the opportunity to meaningfully contribute to something they think is important. Making meaningful contributions requires two things. It requires an idea of what you find important and the skills to take action. Families, faith communities, and friends largely shape the first point but schools are perfectly positioned to provide the second. I therefore argue that the most important purpose of primary and secondary schooling is to teach children the problem-solving skills they need to contribute to their communities because meaningful contribution is one of the most reliable ways people find happiness. In doing so, schools are able to serve both their students and communities. This aim is the best first step but it does raise concerns about what happens to the students who don't have communities outside of school to give them direction.

People need a purpose. Postman describes what happens to people without a purpose in grave detail: "Some commit suicide...Some envelop themselves in drugs, including alcohol...Some encase themselves in an impenetrable egoism" (Postman, 1996, p. 14). It is clear that we need a purpose to be happy but what gives purpose to our lives? To figure this out, I would like to start by examining in more detail the claim made in the 2005 MIT Technology Report. Unemployment is the thing with the single largest

negative impact on happiness. Not poverty, not the death of a family member, not even divorce: unemployment. What is different about employment? Consider what employment provides. Most people devote more time to their job than any other aspect of their life. They have spent years making contributions they feel are meaningful to an organization they find important. They have been rewarded financially by that organization and at times been told their work is really making a difference. Then they get fired and realize that they no longer have anything to contribute to. Devotion to something clearly helps give a person purpose. The scope of things a person could devote themselves to is wide. Paid work, caregiving, civic life, art, service, and many, many other disciplines are all noble causes one could find meaning contributing to. Yet, regardless of what a person chooses, making meaningful contributions still requires the skills to be useful.

If meaningful contribution requires both a sense of what matters and the ability to act on it, the next question is where do each of these come from. A person's sense of what matters can be largely shaped outside of school. Families, faith communities, and friends are all places children can first learn what is worth caring about and they are often better positioned than schools to teach those things. Postman's own experiences illustrate this division. As the child of Jewish parents, he learned his family's traditions at home and believed that "the promotion of ethnicity…was the responsibility of the home" and often "also taken up by one's church or synagogue" (Postman, 1996, p. 17). Some of the worst eras of American education came when schools attempted to teach their students a standardized set of values. Consider the era of Native American boarding schools where

students were forced to cut their hair and abandon their traditions. Schools should not exist to tell each child which causes require their attention.

The second requirement of contribution is where schools become necessary. Whether a student eventually devotes themselves to nursing, local government, farming, or raising a family, they will run into problems with no obvious answer and their ability to contribute will depend on whether they can work through it. Teaching children to define a problem, figure out what they need to understand it, try solutions, and learn from their failures prepares them to contribute to whatever cause they may later choose. This does not mean that schools should try to teach specific skills for each profession. Skill and direction are often developed alongside each other and we can't just wait until a person knows what matters to begin teaching them the specific technical skills they will need to pursue that. This is why I argue that schools should teach more general problem solving skills first before prioritising technical mastery. But why should this purpose take priority over the many others that schools are asked to serve?

Labaree describes American education as a struggle among three competing goals. Schools are trying to make republicans, workers, and winners (Labaree, 1997). The first two goals treat education as a public good to benefit the community while the third treats it as a private good, “a commodity, the only purpose of which is to provide individual students with a competitive advantage” (Labaree, 1997, p. 42). Labaree argues that this third goal has come to dominate. Teaching problem solving as a means to contribute addresses each of these concerns. It serves a public good, a community of people who can identify problems and work through them is better off than one that can't. It also gives individual students something special. Currently, credentials are only

valuable because of their uniqueness, so one student's success comes at another's expense. Reframing education in terms of finding meaning works differently. One student finding purpose in their life takes away nothing from anyone else. In addition, because contribution depends on what a student can actually do rather than what their transcript says, it gives students a real reason to learn rather than to just get by. Promoting the goal of community contribution does not mean other goals should just be abandoned. Labaree warns that "we cannot realistically escape from [this conflict] by just choosing one goal and eliminating the others", since "any healthy society needs an educational system that helps to produce good citizens, good workers, and good social opportunities" (Labaree, 1997, p. 73). My argument is that contribution should be the priority that organizes and ranks the others. A student who can solve problems for their community is already prepared to be an engaged citizen and capable worker, and is better positioned to find opportunity along the way.

My School design project team is redesigning Nantucket High School and we arrived at a similar priority. Our provisional mission statement wants our graduates to "feel prepared and excited to contribute to their local communities". When we pressure tested our design in class 1.8, several very real tensions surfaced. Time spent on long term community projects takes away from the time spent on highly advanced course work. Students who have chosen to pursue academic futures may feel less well served by the schools lack of AP curriculum or extensive ACT prep. I believe this trade off is worth it. The requirement of high level technical courses for college admission is a product of the currently flawed education system. Labaree agrees that the pursuit of credentials has increasingly displaced real learning producing "a futile scramble for higher level

credentials" (Labaree, 1997, p. 72-73). This is not to say that pursuing higher education is wrong, only that we should not compromise the integrity of primary and secondary schooling under the assumption that higher education is the right path for everyone.

A harder problem remains. My argument leaves the question of what happens to students who don't have support from their family, faith, or friends to give them direction. For these students, a school that teaches only skills gives them tools that they have no reason to use. The obvious answer is for schools to somehow offer direction. Postman suggests that schools' influence on student direction is inevitable anyway saying “public education does not serve a public, it creates a public” (Postman, 1996, p. 19). But, the history of Native American boarding schools shows how badly schools can fail when they have to decide what students should value. Ewing argues that “a school means the potential for stability in an unstable world, the potential for agency in the face of powerlessness”, but only when a community feels it has “some say in the matter” (Ewing, 2018, p. 47). For students without strong support at home, I believe the school itself can provide direction, as long as families help shape it rather than having values imposed on them. My best answer for now is that schools should take care to expose students to many different problems worth caring about without deciding which ones students will choose to devote themselves to. Even so, I am still not sure where exactly the line is between giving students the tools to find direction and choosing a purpose for them.

What schools are for will always be contested. Still, I believe that the most important purpose of primary and secondary schooling is to teach children the problem solving skills they need to contribute to their communities because meaningful contribution is one of the most reliable ways people find happiness. This priority serves

both students and communities and it pushes back on a system that too often rewards credentials over real learning.

References:

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